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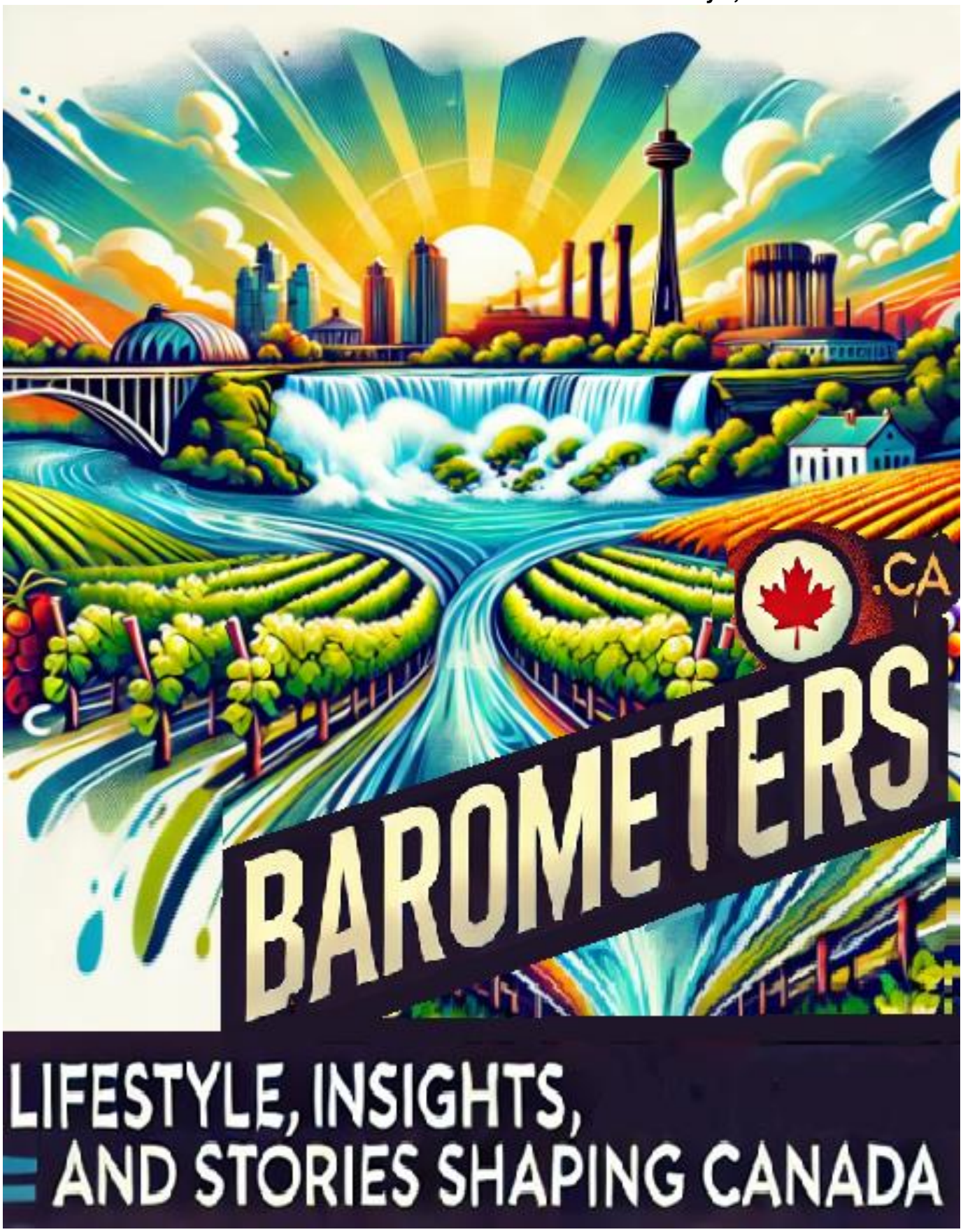
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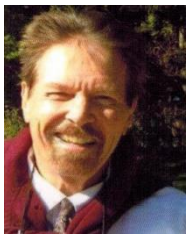
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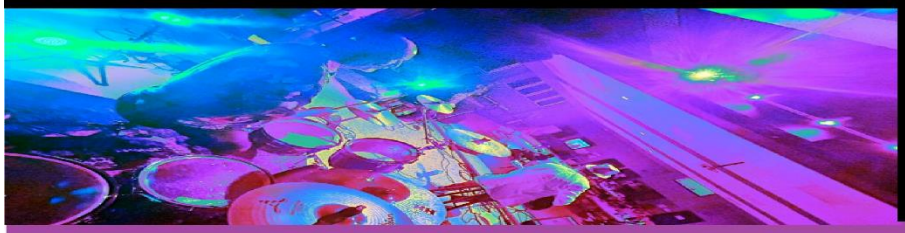
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Bridges Over Battles: Canada and the U.S. from 1812 to Today

As our American neighbours celebrate Independence Day on July 4th – coming just after our own Canada Day – it's an apt time for Canadians to reflect on the ever-evolving relationship between our two countries. Few nations share a connection as intertwined, as friendly, yet as complex as that of Canada and the United States. We are partners in peace, allies in war, rivals in hockey, and companions in culture. How did this special relationship come to be, and where is it headed? To find the answers, one must journey from the battlefields of the distant past to the bridges and shared waters that unite us today.

A War that Forged Peace

The relationship between Canada and the United States was not always the close partnership that we know today. In fact, it was tested by fire during the War of 1812 – a conflict that saw invasions and battles across what is now the Canada–U.S. border. That war, fought from 1812 to 1814, ended essentially in a draw, with the Treaty of Ghent restoring pre-war boundaries. Yet its aftermath set the stage for something remarkable: over two centuries of peaceful coexistence between the two neighbours. Since the guns fell silent in 1814, Canada (then British North America) and the United States have enjoyed an official peace that has lasted to this day. British leaders, chastened by the war's stalemate, sought peaceful relations with the U.S. for the remainder of the 19th century, laying the groundwork for friendship rather than continued hostility.

For Canadians, the War of 1812 also planted seeds of national identity. Local militia and British regulars banded together to repel the American incursions, famously winning battles like the defence of Châteauguay and Lundy's Lane in the Niagara region. Their successful

stand helped initiate a new sense of Canadian identity among the colonists, alongside Indigenous allies who played pivotal roles. Stories of figures like Laura Secord – who trekked through the woods to warn of an American attack – became part of our folklore. In hindsight, the war that once pitted Canadians and Americans against each other ironically forged a lasting peace between them. Indeed, the two countries would never again wage war on one another; instead, they opened a long era of neighbourly relations that endures today. The very fact that no conflict has erupted between Canada and the U.S. since 1814 is a point of quiet pride on both sides of the border.

From Forts to Friendship: A Border Transformed in Niagara

In the early 19th century, the Niagara frontier was dotted with military forts and scarred by conflict. Fort Erie, Queenston Heights, and other sites along the Niagara River were battlegrounds where cannon fire once echoed. Today, those sites are peaceful parks and historic monuments visited by tourists, not soldiers. The transformation of the Niagara border from a line of conflict to a line of friendship did not happen overnight, but it stands as one of the great success stories of diplomacy between our two countries.

One of the first steps toward a peaceful border was the demilitarization of the Great Lakes. In 1817, just a few years after the war, Britain and the U.S. negotiated the Rush–Bagot Agreement to drastically limit naval armaments on the Great Lakes. Both sides agreed to dismantle their warships on those waters and refrain from building new armed vessels. This pact – still technically in force two centuries later – became a powerful symbol of trust. Its spirit has never been violated and it remains a beacon of the long-standing, peaceful relations between Canada and the United States. Thanks to such measures,

the vast boundary between our nations eventually came to be known as the world's longest undefended border, patrolled not by armies but by civilian law enforcement and customs officers.

Nowhere is this peaceful border legacy more evident than in the Niagara region. What was once a fortified frontier has become a place of open commerce and warm neighbourliness. By 1927, the iconic Peace Bridge spanned the Niagara River between Fort Erie, Ontario and Buffalo, New York – so named to commemorate more than a century of peace since the War of 1812. Dignitaries from both nations attended the opening ceremony, where it was noted that the bridge should serve not just as a physical crossing but as a symbol of enduring friendship across the frontier. The Peace Bridge quickly became a vital artery for trade and travel – a concrete monument to how former foes became friends.

For decades, local communities celebrated this cross-border friendship. From 1987 until 2019, the cities of Fort Erie and Buffalo jointly hosted the annual Friendship Festival every summer, timed between Canada Day (July 1) and U.S. Independence Day (July 4). This festival explicitly commemorated nearly two centuries of official peace between Canada and the U.S. since the end of the War of 1812. Neighbours from both sides would gather for concerts, car shows, food, and fireworks, literally partying on the border to celebrate unity in place of division. While the festival ended in 2019, its legacy lives on as a reminder that the Niagara frontier evolved from a war-torn dividing line into a showcase of binational camaraderie.

Cross-Border Neighbours: Niagara's Economic and Cultural Ties

The friendliness is not just symbolic – it's woven into everyday life,

especially in places like Niagara. The communities on either side of the river are deeply intertwined by economics, culture, and family ties. On any given day, thousands of Canadians and Americans crisscross the Niagara region border to work, shop, visit relatives, or simply enjoy the attractions. In fact, before recent disruptions, roughly 400,000 people and over $1.6 billion in goods crossed the Canada–U.S. border every single day. For border residents, popping over to the other side isn't an exotic trip – crossing isn't an annual event, it is a way of life.

This daily exchange underpins a deeply intertwined regional economy. The Niagara corridor is also a bustling trade gateway: the Peace Bridge alone handles more than 1.1 million trucks per year. Canada and the U.S. together share one of the world's largest bilateral trading relationships, exchanging about $2.6 billion in goods and services each day. The prosperity of communities like Fort Erie, Niagara Falls, and Buffalo is closely linked to this cross-border flow of goods and people.

Tourism is also a cornerstone of Niagara's cross-border ties. Niagara Falls has long been a shared wonder, drawing throngs of visitors from both countries. In a typical year, millions of Americans cross into Ontario to experience the famed Horseshoe Falls – and many Canadians also venture stateside for shopping or to cheer on Buffalo's sports teams. This two-way tourism injects prosperity into both communities and reinforces a sense of shared pride in the natural marvel we jointly steward.

Culturally, the Niagara frontier underscores how intertwined Canadians and Americans are. When COVID-19 forced a temporary closure of the border in 2020, cross-border traffic plummeted by over 95%, and many local families suddenly found themselves

separated from loved ones just a few miles away. It was a vivid reminder of how unnatural it is for life in this region to be divided – a testament to decades of friendship and trust that normally make the border almost invisible.

Changing Perspectives on America

Over time, Canadians' perception of America has shifted along with history. In the 19th century, our forebears eyed the young republic warily. The memory of 1812 and U.S. expansionist talk of "Manifest Destiny" fueled fears of annexation – even contributing to Canada's Confederation in 1867 – and cross-border skirmishes like the Fenian Raids of the 1860s only reinforced that caution. But as the 20th century progressed, outright fear gave way to familiarity, respect, and even affection. The United States became a close wartime ally and economic partner, and for much of the late 1900s roughly three-quarters of Canadians held a favorable opinion of the U.S. Still, Canadians did not hesitate to disagree with American policies – from the Vietnam War to the 2003 Iraq invasion – reflecting an independent streak even amid friendship.

In the 21st century, Canadian views of the U.S. have ebbed and flowed with events. After the unity and outpouring of sympathy in the wake of the September 11, 2001 attacks – when Canadians famously opened their homes and airports to stranded American travelers – the Iraq War and other controversies began a downward trend in approval. The election of Donald Trump marked a dramatic low point: by 2020, only about a third of Canadians had a positive view of the U.S. While sentiments improved after 2021, they have since fallen again – as of early 2025, barely one in four Canadians voices a favorable opinion of America. Such wariness is largely directed at U.S. leadership and policies, not ordinary Americans. At a personal level, the

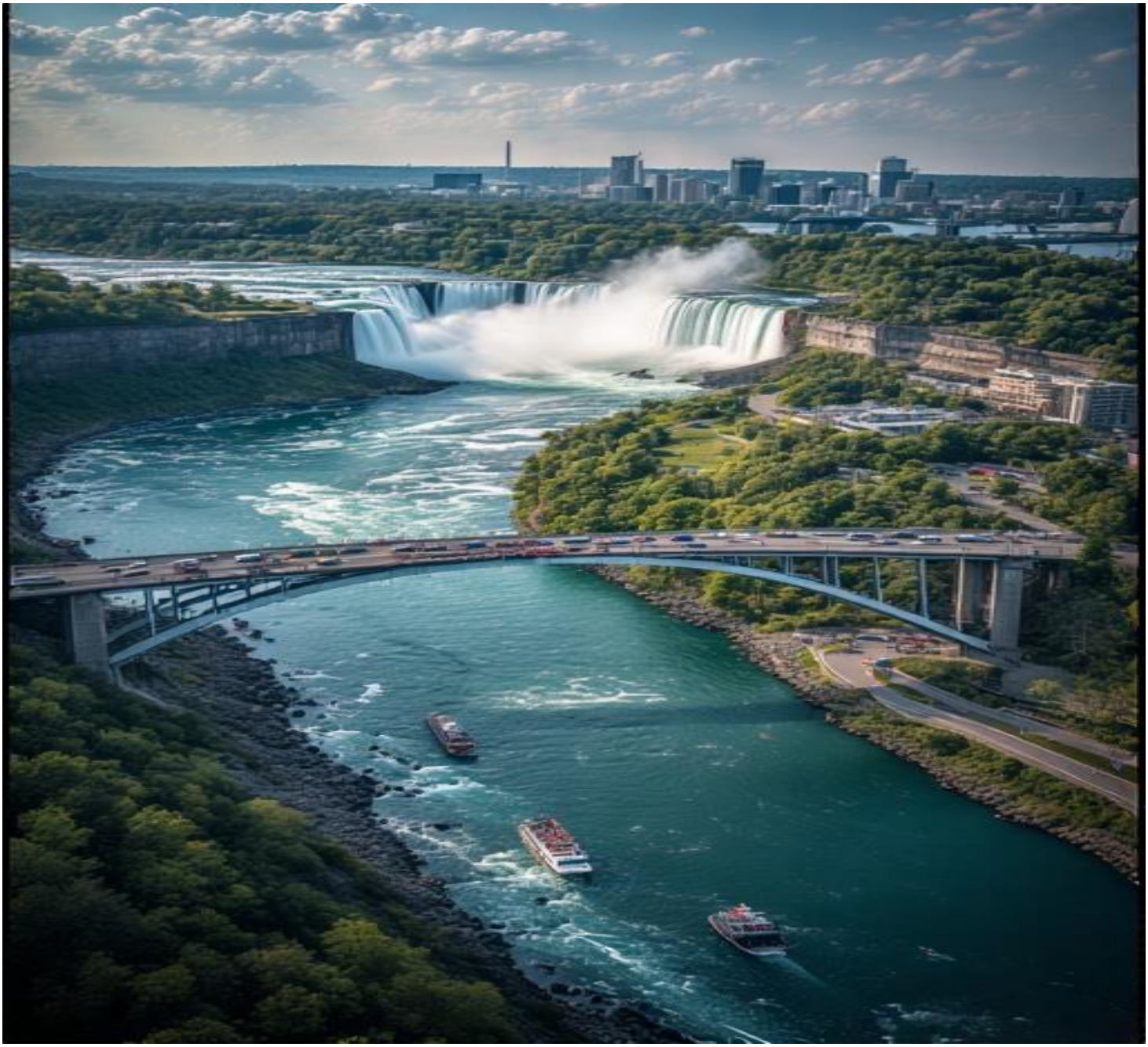
warmth endures: Canadians and Americans still mingle, work, and play together with an easy familiarity. We share fundamental values of democracy and freedom, and we see each other not as foreigners but as family – sometimes like siblings who bicker, yet fundamentally have each other's backs.

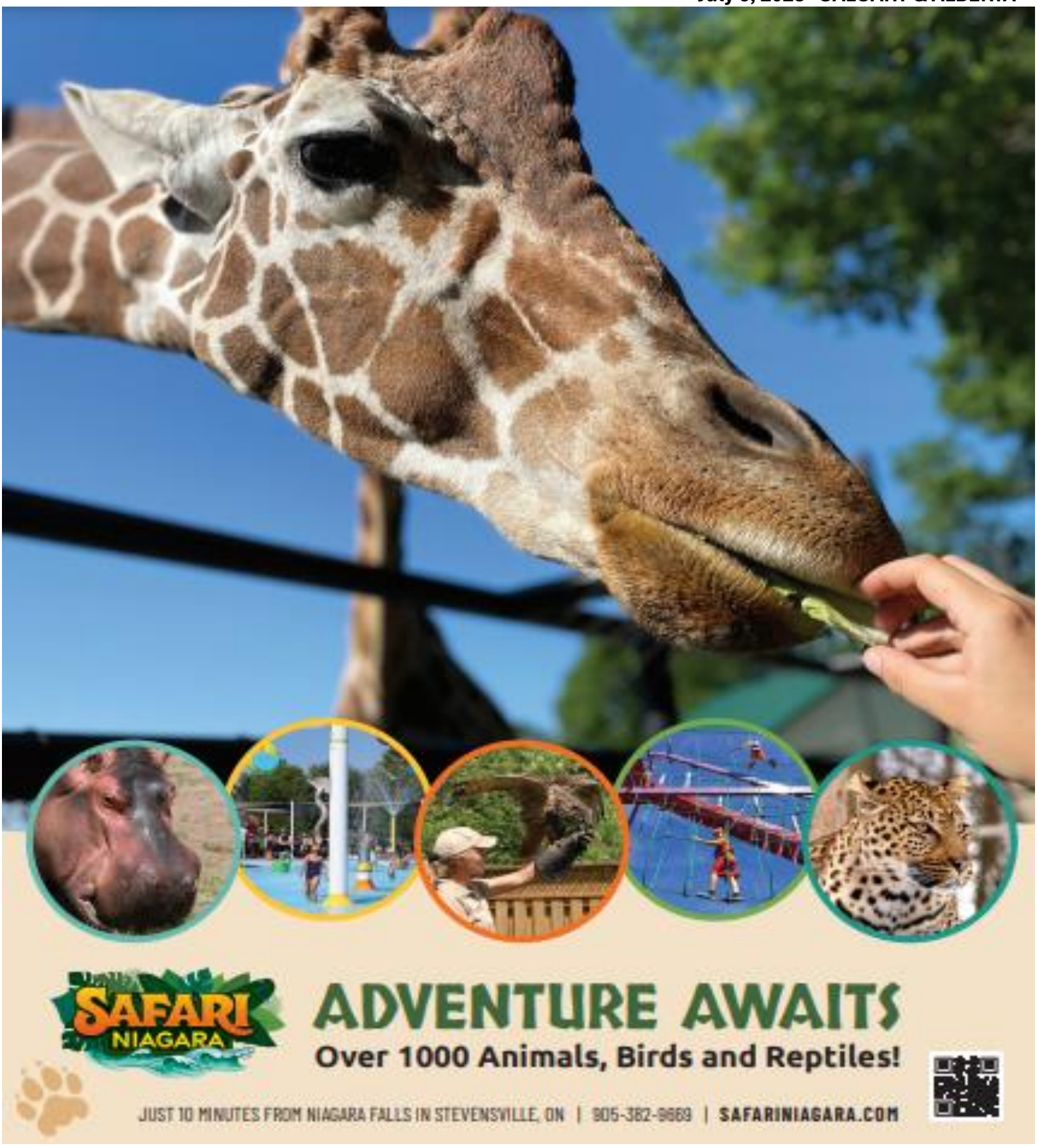
Charting a Shared Future

Looking ahead, there is ample reason for hope – as well as responsibility – in the Canada–U.S. partnership. We have built robust institutions to handle whatever challenges tomorrow brings. For example, in protecting our shared environment, Canada and the U.S. have long worked side by side. The Great Lakes, which form part of our border, are safeguarded by joint agreements like the Great Lakes Water Quality Agreement, first signed in 1972. As climate change tests our ecosystems, this spirit of cooperation must deepen – whether it's cleaning up pollution, managing water levels, or balancing hydroelectric needs with preserving natural beauty, as in the 1950 treaty governing Niagara Falls. Likewise, maintaining a border that is secure yet welcoming will demand continued coordination. We proudly share the world's longest undefended border, an achievement built on mutual trust. By sharing intelligence, aligning our security efforts, and supporting each other in crises, we make both nations safer and stronger.

Ultimately, the friendship between Canada and the U.S. is a remarkable model in a turbulent world. In fact, the journey from enmity to alliance between our countries offers hope that even long-standing adversaries can become the closest of partners. In an era of global uncertainty, this partnership remains a cornerstone of stability and prosperity for both nations. We may have occasional quarrels or competitions – a bit like siblings – but fundamentally we stand together. Geography made us

neighbours; choice made us partners. As Americans celebrate their Independence Day, Canadians can reflect with pride on a relationship defined not by conflict, but by cooperation. Our history shows that two countries can move from war to peace and prosper together. That is a bond worth honoring – on July 4th, and every day.




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Michelle Paroschy: The Flavorful Visionary Behind "Mama Yum Yum" in Niagara Falls

Nestled in the heart of Niagara Falls, Michelle Paroschy has emerged not just as a local business owner—but as a culinary innovator reshaping the baby-food landscape. Her brand, **Mama Yum Yum**, stands as a testament to her passion for quality, community, and healthy beginnings for the littlest members of our region.

Parents today are more informed and discerning than ever. They look beyond convenience, favoring fresh, transparent, and nutrient-rich feeding options. Paroschy's focus on wholesome ingredients—think ripe peaches, tender heirloom tomatoes, and award-winning regional cheeses—resonates strongly with this growing demand. In the process, she's solidified her role as more than a supplier: she's a trusted guide for parents navigating the early stages of their child's dietary journey.

What began as a series of home-cooked batches for family and friends has flourished into a fully licensed production facility, recognized by health authorities for its dedication to food safety and community wellness. Michelle's journey reflects a broader shift: small-batch, locally driven food entrepreneurship is gaining momentum across Niagara. Not only does it support regional agriculture and economy, but it also creates a sense of closeness and trust—something big brands often lack.

For Paroschy, advocacy for infant nutrition is personal. As a mother, she saw firsthand the disconnect between glossy, commercial baby food packaging and the scarcer nutritional truths hidden inside. Motivated to offer an alternative, she launched *Mama Yum Yum* with the belief that every child deserves food that aligns with both taste and health.

Her flavors—whether a delicate apple-carrot mash or a savory

lentil-sweet potato blend—are rooted in nutritional science and regional produce, supporting local farmers and reducing food miles.



Like most small businesses, Paroschy faced hurdles. Transitioning her venture to meet commercial licensing requirements involved navigating regulation, training, and compliance procedures. Yet her responsive nature turned each step into a story—from the first health inspection to late-night recipe tweaks and community-driven taste testing. This grit has fostered strong relationships with both parents and local health advocates, who appreciate not only the product but Michelle's authenticity and openness about her process.

Mama Yum Yum is now featuring seasonal menus, aligning with harvest windows and local availability. Summer offerings—like peach-vanilla puree or zucchini-pea medleys—highlight fresh, regional flavor. Paroschy frequently partners with local artisans, including Niagara-grown goat cheeses and cider pairings, making her baby food both relevant and sophisticated.

Her emphasis on sustainability—organic packaging, recyclable materials, and supplier transparency—further appeals to

eco-conscious families who value ethical footprints as much as nutritional density.

Beyond jars and labels, Michelle embodies civic entrepreneurship. She hosts baby-food preparation workshops, attends farmer's markets with live demos, and speaks at parenting circles, sharing insights on weaning, avoiding allergens, and choosing balanced infant diets. She's also made connections with pediatricians and dietitians—garnering professional trust through evidence-based nutrition, positive feedback, and concrete results in children's health and feeding transitions.

Despite growing demand, Michelle remains committed to keeping production local and hands-on. She plans to launch a subscription-based model later this year—allowing parents to customize delivery bundles based on age and dietary preferences. Additionally, she's eyeing partnerships with daycare centers and maternity-support organizations to further reach families in need.

Succession plans are also underway: Paroschy hopes to mentor another local food entrepreneur to join her team, ensuring *Mama Yum Yum's* legacy extends well beyond her own leadership.

Michelle Paroschy's journey touches on broader themes that matter in Niagara today: quality food systems, mindful parenting, female-led entrepreneurship, and smart local investment. Her baby-food brand mirrors the region's agricultural richness and its modern spirit—rooted in place, but with a finger on the pulse of contemporary health trends. As Niagara-on-the-Lake's vineyards and orchards continue to draw acclaim, innovators like Michelle weave these natural gifts into meaningful, daily life—nurturing tomorrow's generation, one spoonful at a time.

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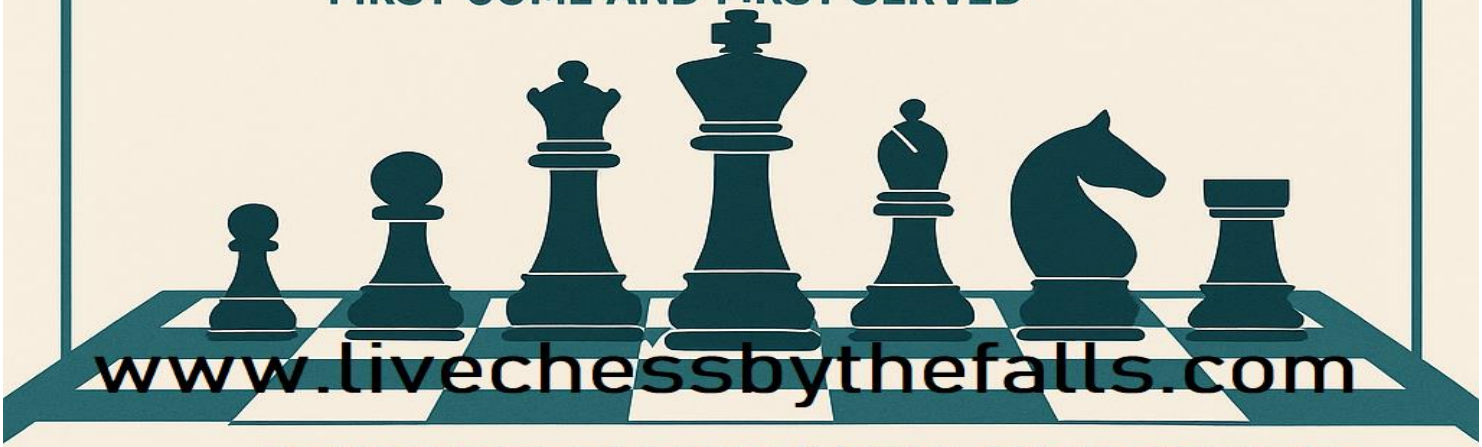
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Fort Erie at a Crossroads: Can it Become a Hub for Industry and Tech?

Fort Erie has always occupied a strategic place on the Canadian map. Perched right along the Niagara River, across from Buffalo, New York, it is a border town in every sense: a gateway to one of the world's largest economies, blessed with logistical advantages that most communities can only envy. Yet despite this enviable geography, Fort Erie's aspirations to become a modern industrial and technology hub are still more potential than reality. The question that should haunt the council chambers at Town Hall — and every resident invested in their children's futures — is: why?

The border advantage: still untapped

Talk to local boosters and they'll point immediately to Fort Erie's location. Few places can boast three international border crossings within a short drive — the Peace Bridge being the crown jewel — along with direct road access to the QEW, CN and CP rail links, and proximity to major airports in Buffalo and Toronto. This is exactly why logistics companies have long clustered here, from cross-border trucking operations to customs brokers.

But what about beyond trucks and warehouses? Could Fort Erie parlay its border proximity into something far more dynamic: a centre for advanced manufacturing, cross-border technology startups, or a landing spot for US companies seeking a cost-effective Canadian base?

So far, the answer has been underwhelming. Industrial parks exist, yes — but they mostly house low to mid-scale warehousing and light manufacturing. Meanwhile, Niagara Falls and St. Catharines have moved aggressively to attract tech and innovation corridors, drawing investment dollars and

partnerships that Fort Erie has struggled to land.

Weaknesses in the current strategy

This is where Fort Erie's leadership — from council to the mayor's office — needs to confront some hard truths. The town has relied too long on its border advantage as a passive selling point. Infrastructure plans remain piecemeal, marketing efforts are scattershot, and economic development policies often seem stuck in the 1990s. While other Niagara municipalities have overhauled zoning to fast-track innovation hubs, Fort Erie still debates minor site plan variances for months. The result is lost time and lost investors.

There's also the problem of vision. Fort Erie's municipal approach is still heavily skewed toward short-term tax growth through residential builds and casino revenue rather than a long-term industrial strategy. This risks becoming a bedroom community for wealthier Niagara cities and Buffalo commuters — which may fill municipal coffers today but does little to secure robust, diverse employment opportunities for tomorrow.

Mayor Wayne Redekop and council have periodically talked about "positioning Fort Erie for the next generation," but specifics are often lacking. A few grants for business facade improvements downtown or general platitudes about tourism do not a trade and technology hub make. There's a deeper need for aggressive, coordinated action.

A young population at stake

Perhaps the most concerning outcome is what this means for young Fort Erie residents. High school graduates eyeing careers in IT, advanced manufacturing, or emerging tech find few pathways at home. Instead, they head to Niagara Falls, Hamilton, Kitchener-Waterloo, or across the border to Buffalo and beyond.

This brain drain is particularly acute because once young talent leaves, it rarely returns. They settle where they find opportunity — and Fort Erie's quiet streets, though appealing for retirees or day-trippers, do not compete with bustling tech corridors when it comes to dynamic careers.

If Fort Erie is to reverse this trend, it must think boldly. A town of roughly 33,000 will never be a Toronto or Buffalo — but it doesn't need to be. With smart policies, it could carve out niches in cross-border logistics tech, advanced material processing, or even niche software startups focused on international trade compliance. That would mean jobs not just in warehouses, but in engineering, coding, and management — exactly the kind that keep young families in town.

What needs to change?

So what should Fort Erie's roadmap look like if it's serious about becoming an industrial and tech trade centre?

1. A real economic cluster strategy

The first priority must be for Fort Erie to stop trying to be everything to everyone. Other municipalities have succeeded by picking specific clusters to champion. Waterloo went for computer engineering; Hamilton doubled down on health sciences and advanced manufacturing. Fort Erie could target trade tech, cross-border compliance solutions, and advanced logistics software — natural fits given its location.

To do this, council needs to commission a sophisticated cluster strategy, involving local businesses, Niagara College, Brock University, Buffalo's tech incubators, and cross-border chambers of commerce. Stop with generic "open for business" slogans — start building tailored incentives for targeted industries.

2. Infrastructure beyond roads

Yes, good roads matter — but so do broadband speeds. If Fort Erie wants to host even small startups or attract US-based firms opening satellite

offices, it needs world-class fibre optic capacity, industrial parks ready with cutting-edge utilities, and streamlined permitting.

Fast-tracking zoning approvals for identified tech and light-industrial zones is essential. Right now, it can still take over a year to clear hurdles that better-prepared municipalities can greenlight in six months.

3. Workforce development tied to local industries

A local industrial future demands homegrown talent. That means partnerships with Niagara College and Brock to offer certificate and diploma programs specifically geared to Fort Erie's targeted clusters — courses in supply chain tech, trade law software, smart manufacturing systems. Subsidize co-op placements in town so students see Fort Erie as more than just a place to live, but a place to build a career.

4. Cross-border collaborative offices

Fort Erie needs a permanent economic development office that works in tandem with Buffalo's business community. That could mean shared trade expos, joint start-up accelerators, or even a small shared cross-border "innovation campus" near the Peace Bridge. Municipal staff must actively attend US trade shows and court investment in person.

5. Marketing that speaks to young professionals

Fort Erie's promotional materials tend to highlight quaintness, golf, the horse track, and boating. That's lovely for tourism — but a young software engineer from Buffalo looking to build an app that tracks international freight compliance wants to know about coworking spaces, incubators, nightlife and networking events.

City marketing needs a rebrand: from quiet border town to energetic binational trade tech hub. That doesn't mean abandoning Fort Erie's

charm — it means telling a story that young entrepreneurs find compelling.

A moment of opportunity

Ironically, the global economy's current uncertainty may be Fort Erie's best opening. As US and Canadian firms look to diversify supply chains and bring operations closer to home, cross-border towns like Fort Erie are uniquely positioned. Logistics firms are scouting for cheaper Canadian land to offset Buffalo's high warehouse costs. US manufacturers exploring secondary plants eye towns with fast customs links. Even small fintech startups see opportunities to build platforms that help businesses navigate the complexity of shipping across the longest undefended border in the world.

Fort Erie could seize this moment. But it will require its leadership to be less passive, less content to let the casino or residential developers dictate the future, and more focused on creating an economy that offers real, long-term prospects for the next generation.

Looking ahead

Fort Erie stands at a crossroads, both literally and figuratively. Its next moves will determine whether it becomes a modern industrial and tech centre — or continues to be a pretty border town overshadowed by more ambitious neighbours. For residents who want to see their kids find careers at home, not across the river or across the country, the stakes couldn't be higher.

The path forward isn't a mystery. It's the willingness to execute — to build infrastructure, court targeted investment, overhaul bureaucracy, and speak the language of young innovators — that will determine whether Fort Erie finally capitalizes on its border advantage. The time to act is now. If the mayor and council truly want to make Fort Erie a centre of trade and technology, the



blueprint is clear. All that's left is the political will to get it done.



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Calgary's Next Frontier: Transformation into a Global Business Powerhouse

Calgary is in the midst of a remarkable economic transformation. No longer tethered solely to its oil and gas roots, the city is aggressively diversifying into technology, renewable energy, real estate, and infrastructure. This new multi-faceted approach positions Calgary to capture emerging opportunities and sustain long-term growth.

---

1. A Tech & Innovation Boom

Calgary is fast emerging as a North American tech and data hub. Bolstered by a growing pool of skilled professionals and digital infrastructure investments, the city hosts a vibrant startup scene. Incubators, accelerators, and university-industry partnerships are helping drive growth. Trade-led investments have surged, with significant job creation and increased foreign investment. This tech momentum is reshaping Calgary's economic identity.

---

2. Evolving Energy Through Clean Technology

While Alberta's traditional strength lies in oil and gas, Calgary is embracing its evolution into renewable energy and cleantech. A wave of clean energy projects in and around the city is revitalizing commercial real estate and spurring advanced manufacturing initiatives. This shift signals a strategic pivot that blends old strengths with new sustainability goals.

---

3. Real Estate & Infrastructure: Building the Future

Office-to-residential conversions: Calgary has introduced generous subsidies to convert underutilized office towers into residential units, breathing life back into the downtown core. Over 2,000 units are

currently underway.
Major urban projects: The skyline is being redefined by sustainable mixed-use towers, while the upcoming Rivers District redevelopment introduces a state-of-the-art venue connected to transit.
Green Line LRT: A transformative public transit initiative, the Green Line will link the southeast and north-central districts through downtown. With a scheduled Phase 1 launch around 2031, this project is primed to unlock new transit-oriented development opportunities.

---

4. Economic Outlook: Resilient With Caveats

Calgary's economic forecast for 2025–2030 predicts stronger growth than the broader province or country, driven by expanded energy exports and favorable interest rates. However, challenges persist: unemployment remains elevated, job growth is tapering, and global trade uncertainties continue to weigh on investor confidence.

---

5. Strategic Opportunities Ahead

1. Tech scale-up: Boost funding for incubators and accelerators, deepen university-industry collaboration, and bridge capital gaps for early-stage startups.
2. Transit-Oriented Development (TOD): Use Green Line to drive clusters of affordable housing, coworking spaces, data centres, and clean-tech zones.
3. Industrial diversification: Support light manufacturing and cleantech near transport hubs, alongside cold-chain logistics facilities.
4. Workforce readiness: Align educational programs with emerging sectors, offering paid internships and skill-based

training in data, cleantech, and digital industries.

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6. Risks & Gaps: From Strategy to Execution

- Overreliance on subsidies: While subsidies have jumpstarted conversions, escalating construction costs threaten viability. Calgary must shift to market-responsive incentives—like tax breaks and flexible zoning—while ensuring affordable housing is part of the mix.
- Infrastructure delays: Political wrangling has slowed the Green Line. Calgary needs stronger federal and provincial partnerships to accelerate procurement and execution.
- Talent and affordability mismatch: Rising housing costs and slow employment gains demand focused investment in workforce development and housing solutions.
- Energy dependency: Though progress is visible, Calgary's economy remains linked to oil-price cycles. Accelerated support for cleantech pilot projects and energy transitions is essential.

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7. Recommendations for Sustained Momentum

- Fast-track Green Line + TOD zoning: Foster dense, transit-connected neighborhoods that support digital and clean-tech industries.
- Shift from reactive subsidies: Incentivize with market mechanisms that address social objectives, like affordability and sustainability.
- Invest in youth and diversity: Launch targeted upskilling initiatives and inclusive hiring in tech and cleantech.

- Champion cleantech innovation: Establish R&D grants and innovation hubs focused on energy transition technologies.

The Bottom Line

Calgary now has the opportunity to rebrand itself as more than Alberta's energy city—it's on track to become Western Canada's innovation powerhouse. The city is making strategic investments in diversification, infrastructure, and workforce development. To convert potential into reality, Calgary must streamline execution, support its young talent, and adopt policies that reflect its broadening economic base.

If Calgary embraces transit-oriented growth, market-driven incentives, inclusive workforce planning, and cleantech leadership, it could redefine itself on the global stage. The city may soon be recognized not just for its oil



fame—but as a resilient, forward-looking hub of trade, technology, and innovation.

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Calgary's Family Scene: Raising Kids in Alberta's Biggest City

When envisioning Alberta as a place to raise a family, Calgary often shines. With its blend of affordability, amenities, and quality of life, it stands out—not just within the province but nationally. But how does it compare to other Alberta cities like Edmonton, Lethbridge, and Fort McMurray?

Calgary: Big City with a Family Focus

Affordability & Economy

Calgary ranks among the *lowest-cost major Canadian cities*, according to Mercer's 2024 Cost of Living Index, trailing only Edmonton in housing affordability. With the absence of provincial sales tax and average family incomes around $110K or less, a comfortable life is attainable for most households.

Education & Childcare

The city boasts a robust public and private school system with over 1000 schools (public and Catholic) throughout K–12. Alberta's government also subsidizes childcare, making it as low as $10 per day for many families.

Quality of Life & Amenities

Consistently rated one of the most livable cities globally, Calgary offers nearly 8,000 ha of parks, extensive pathways, and easy access to nature—family staples. Community events like the Calgary Stampede, Heritage Park, and accessible cultural hubs enrich family life. The 21-branch Calgary Public Library further supports literacy and learning .

Safety

Low provincial crime rates make Calgary—and Alberta at large—a secure environment for raising kids.

Edmonton: Comparable, Different Vibes

Edmonton shares many of Calgary's positives—affordable housing, strong schools, and urban parks, especially its massive river valley system. It's also known as "Festival City," offering cultural energy via events like the Fringe and robust arts infrastructure. Some families prefer Edmonton for its quieter pace and diverse cultural offerings.

🏠 Lethbridge: Small City Charms

With a metro population of ~124,000, Lethbridge offers a more intimate community feel. It's appreciated for its affordability—housing remains cheaper than in Calgary and Edmonton—and strong school and arts foundations, including Japanese gardens and the High Level Bridge. It excels at small-city livability, though may lack the economic dynamism of larger centers.

🛢️ Fort McMurray: Boomtown Challenges

Fort McMurray's economy is dominated by oil sands—bringing both high income potential and volatility.While well-paid, families face expensive housing and infrastructure challenges tied to boom-and-bust cycles. Educational offerings exist but may be limited compared to major urban centers.

🧩 Calgary's Unique Strengths

1. **Affordability and income balance** – Competitive cost of living, strong wages.
2. **Comprehensive education** – Wide-reaching public system and childcare subsidies.
3. **Outdoor lifestyle** – Massive urban park systems, outdoor programs year-round.
4. **Cultural richness** – Events, museums, performance venues, and libraries in abundance.

⚠️ Areas for Improvement

1. **Childcare accessibility**
   - Affordability is supported, but service availability varies. More spaces and hours would benefit working families.
2. **Transition to adult services**
   - Fast-growing teen population needs expanded youth programs, mental health supports, and career pathways.
3. **Housing diversity**
   - Suburban sprawl limits options. More family-size units in core areas would keep families connected and reduce commuting.
4. **School capacity alignment**
   - Rapidly growing neighborhoods face overcrowding. Proactive school infrastructure planning is crucial.
5. **Transportation for families**
   - While cost-effective, transit service gaps remain in suburban areas—affecting non-drivers like teens and children.

✅ What It Takes to Improve Outcomes for Young Families

- **Expand licensed childcare and wrap-around programs** in mixed-income neighborhoods to ease working-parent pressures.
- **Boost youth outreach services**, like after-school centers, mental health access, and vocational accelerators.

- **Adopt mixed-housing policies**, incentivizing infill developments with townhomes and duplexes suitable for families.

📊 Comparison Snapshot

Feature	Calgary	Edmonton	Lethbridge	Fort McMurray
Housing Affordability	Strong (with growth pressure)	Strong	Very Strong	Weak
Income Levels	High	Comparable	Moderate	High, volatile
Education Quality	Strong range	Strong	Strong	Moderate
Childcare Access	Needs growth	Needs growth	Needs growth	Limited
Youth Services	Growing gap	Growing need	Small-city gap	Transitional services
Transit Availability	Good in core	Good	Moderate	Limited

- **Synchronize school planning with growth** to pre-empt overcrowding and expand extracurricular offerings.
- **Enhance transit**, especially around schools, libraries, and community centers; explore subsidized youth transit options.

💡 Final Thoughts

For young families, Calgary offers unmatched balance in Alberta—affordable living within a vibrant,

resource-rich city that supports education, health, leisure, and culture. It outpaces smaller centres in services, and while it lacks oil-driven volatility of Fort McMurray, it still benefits from economic consistency. Building on its strengths—by expanding childcare, youth programs, housing options, and transport—can elevate Calgary's family appeal further today and for the next generation.



In the end, Calgary doesn't just raise children—it raises communities. With focused municipal efforts, it's poised to remain Alberta's family-first city for years to come.


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Nedley "Ned" Pitt

January 12, 1967 – June 18, 2025

It is with profound sadness that we announce the passing of Nedley "Ned" Pitt, aged 58, of Ottawa. Born on January 12, 1967, Ned was a devoted son, brother, and friend whose warmth and musical spirit touched everyone he met.

Ned brought joy and rhythm into people's lives through his talent as a bass guitarist. As a vibrant presence in Ottawa's music community for many years, he performed with local bands, enlivening venues and events with his soulful grooves and heartfelt commitment. His music was both passion and gift, forging connections across audiences and fellow musicians alike. True to his generous nature, Ned shared his gift freely, mentoring aspiring players and brightening countless local stages.

Beyond his musical talents, Ned was beloved for his genuine kindness, infectious laughter, and welcoming spirit. He will be deeply missed by his mother, Sheila; his brothers, Ramsey and Gerry; aunts Dorothy, Ina, Ruby, Allison, Valerie, Hollie; uncles Vincent, Wayne, Cecil, and Vernon; as well as his many nieces, nephews, cousins, and a wide circle



of friends who were all privileged to know him.

The Pitt family extends heartfelt thanks for the outpouring of love, memories, and anecdotes shared during this difficult time. They cherish and draw strength from these reflections of Ned's generous Christian soul and the joy he brought into so many lives.



In lieu of flowers, the family invites donations to a local music education charity—continuing Ned's legacy of inspiring others through music. Messages, memories, and photos may be shared through a memorial page hosted by Maison funéraire Racine, Robert & Gauthier.



Ned's presence brought light and harmony; in his memory, may we each carry forward the kindness, creativity, and shared appreciation of music he embodied. Rest in peace, Ned—you will be remembered always.



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Andrew Haydon Park: Ottawa's Natural Stage Welcomes Summer Sounds

Set along the sweeping south shore of the Ottawa River, Andrew Haydon Park is one of the city's most scenic green spaces. With its serene ponds, iconic sailboat views, and wide-open lawns dotted with mature willow trees, it's long been a go-to spot for family picnics, dog walks, and quiet afternoon reading. But in recent years, it's also grown into something more dynamic: one of Ottawa's most promising outdoor concert venues.

That promise will be on full display on **Saturday, July 19, 2025**, when Andrew Haydon Park hosts a full day of music and community gathering under the banner of **The Ottawa Music Festival**. Running from **12 noon to 8 p.m.**, with live performances kicking off at **2 p.m.**, this event aims to fuse Ottawa's love of nature with its thriving independent music scene.

A Park Made for Concerts

Unlike hardscape plazas or fenced-off fairgrounds, Andrew Haydon Park was practically designed by nature to be a concert venue. Its rolling lawns form a natural amphitheatre that slopes gently toward the river, offering excellent sightlines whether you're stretched out on a picnic blanket near the front or relaxing under a tree farther back. A steady river breeze keeps things comfortable even on the warmest days, and the sunsets over the Ottawa River can transform a late set into something almost magical.

Amenities abound for families and visitors making a day of it. Well-maintained public washrooms, ample parking, and wide paths for strollers or wheelchairs ensure accessibility for all. The park's ponds—often visited by geese, herons, and curious turtles—provide a peaceful backdrop between sets, while kids can explore the

playground or simply run free in the sprawling open space.

What to Expect on July 19

The Ottawa Music Festival has built a reputation for showcasing some of the region's most compelling up-and-coming talent alongside beloved local staples. This year's afternoon-to-evening show promises no different. The lineup—released on **www.theottawamusicfestival.ca**—features a diverse roster ranging from indie rock and folk to soulful jazz ensembles and singer-songwriter sets.

Gates open at **12 noon**, inviting festival-goers to set up their spots early. There will be stands serving **classic chili and regular hot dogs**, alongside **ice-cold beer, coolers, pop, and bottled water**. It's a simple, timeless summer fare that suits the relaxed vibe perfectly and keeps the focus on the music and community.

The performances start at **2 p.m.**, rolling through multiple sets until close to **8 p.m.** Attendees are encouraged to bring their own low-slung chairs or blankets to settle in for an afternoon of festival-style listening.

Why Andrew Haydon Park Works

Ottawa has no shortage of indoor venues, from intimate clubs to the grandeur of the National Arts Centre. But outdoor shows at Andrew Haydon Park strike a different chord. They feel personal yet expansive, vibrant yet laid-back. Part of it comes down to sheer atmosphere: the gentle ripple of the river just beyond the stage, the laughter of children echoing through the trees, the long summer light that makes the evening linger.

It's also deeply local. Unlike downtown festival grounds that can feel hemmed in by traffic or concrete, Andrew Haydon Park gives festival-goers a true sense of

Ottawa's connection to its riverside heritage. You're just as likely to see neighbors catching up over coolers as you are musicians mingling with fans after their sets.

A Model for Accessible Culture

One of the most important aspects of these concerts is how they break down barriers to live music. They're easy to reach—located just off Carling Avenue, close to transit routes and cycling paths—and designed to be welcoming to all ages. Whether you're a college student, a young family, or retired and looking to spend a summer afternoon by the water, the park concert experience is built to include you.

Organizers of The Ottawa Music Festival have also been especially mindful to keep ticket costs modest and amenities family-friendly. For many local musicians, it means a chance to perform for bigger, multigenerational audiences, forging new fans in the most organic way possible.

Looking Ahead

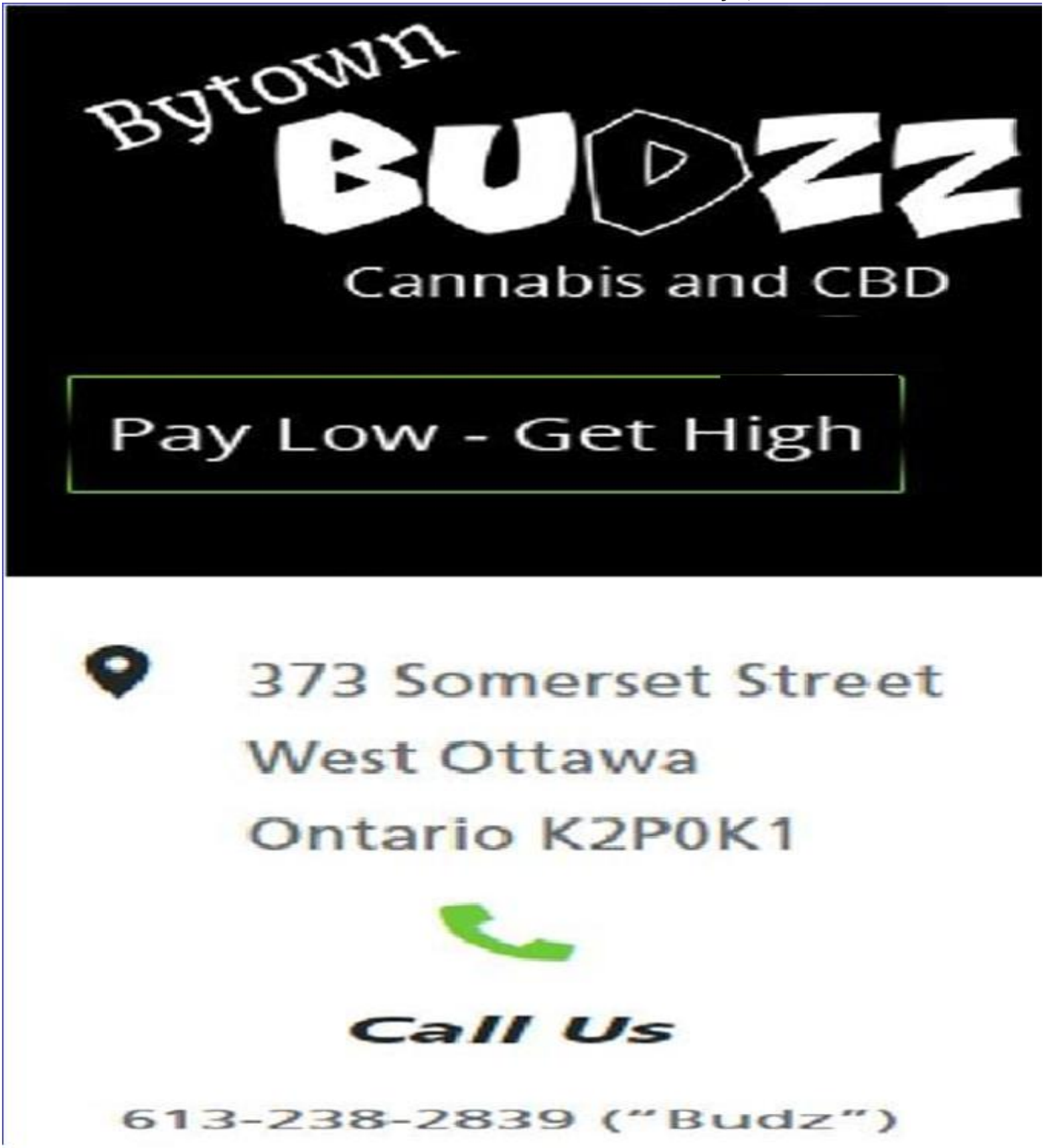
If Andrew Haydon Park continues on this trajectory, it could become a seasonal landmark in Ottawa's cultural calendar, rivaling major outdoor venues in other Canadian cities. Its combination of natural beauty, accessibility, and community-first spirit makes it uniquely positioned to thrive.

So pack a blanket, grab some sunscreen, and circle **July 19** on your calendar. The Ottawa Music Festival promises not just an afternoon of great local music, but an experience that blends the best of Ottawa: friendly faces, artistic passion, and the quiet majesty of a river that's always been at the heart of the city's story.

For details on the lineup, tickets, and what to bring, visit www.theottawamusicfestival.ca.



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The Hidden Cost: How Cheap Drugs Thrive When Economic Purpose Disappears

Across many parts of Canada, from Ottawa's overlooked corners to the once-hopeful industrial hubs of Niagara, Belleville, Prince Edward County, and even the outwardly prosperous Calgary, there lies a shadow story rarely confronted directly: what happens when meaningful economic purpose ebbs away, leaving cheap, ever-available drugs to fill the void? The social consequences run far deeper than the immediate tragedies of overdoses or street-level crime. They entrench new patterns of dependence — not just on substances, but on public systems ill-equipped to rebuild lost community resilience.

This story is neither purely moral nor purely economic. It is the byproduct of frayed opportunity, stalled wages, unaffordable housing, and the slow withdrawal of institutions that once provided a sense of belonging. In their place, illicit economies blossom, serving as both anesthetic and income stream. And inevitably, the personal wreckage emerges most visibly in children born into fragile homes — often to single mothers, some still nearly children themselves, whose partners have vanished into the prison system, an overdose, or simply drifted away under the weight of addiction.

Economic retreat: the precondition for despair

Each of these Canadian regions has faced versions of the same narrative. In Niagara, a slow decline in manufacturing hollowed out the stable union jobs that once paid for mortgages, vacations, and hockey gear. In Belleville and Prince Edward County, agriculture has transformed under consolidation pressures, while the influx of short-term tourism can't sustain full-time, year-round employment for many residents.

Ottawa, despite its federal backbone, has long hidden zones of economic precarity: neighbourhoods where young people see little beyond transient contract work or gig economy scrambles. In Calgary, the oil boom's peaks and crashes have left a generation caught between dreams of six-figure trades jobs and the brutal reality of downturn layoffs, vacancy signs dotting strip malls that once buzzed.

In these gaps, cheap drugs — opioids, meth, increasingly laced stimulants and benzos — become both solace and currency. Dealers do not perform credit checks. They do not judge tattoos, eviction histories, or criminal records. They sell hope by the gram, a promise of momentary escape from a life that otherwise feels directionless.

The lure of drugs as social infrastructure

In healthier economic climates, much of daily life is scaffolded by routines built around work: early mornings, reliable paycheques, camaraderie, a sense that tomorrow may be better than today. In their absence, the drug economy provides its own routines — meet-ups, small hustles to get by, micro-networks of trust and mutual obligation that replace traditional workplaces.

This is especially true in places where long hours of underemployment create days to fill. It is no accident that street-level drug networks often flourish in the same post-industrial neighbourhoods where "help wanted" signs grow scarce or only advertise casual, minimum-wage shifts with no benefits. The street economy steps into the gap, providing social belonging along with financial survival.

The pattern plays out with tragic predictability: people self-medicate against depression or boredom; small-time dealing covers rent or bail money; violence follows to defend

tiny slices of the local market. In time, the drugs themselves reshape the community, changing who gathers on corners, who hangs out in playgrounds, who is left to raise children when partners vanish.

The impact on family structures: silent crisis of single mothers

Perhaps the deepest long-term consequence appears in the form of single mothers, many unwed, often unsupported, raising children while drawing on a patchwork of family resources, state programs, or nothing at all.

In Ottawa's Vanier or Carlington, you'll find these stories in modest apartments, where young mothers rely on ageing grandparents for rent top-ups and emergency childcare. In Belleville's east end or small towns around Prince Edward County, the pattern repeats: grandparents quietly mortgage homes to support daughters who struggle with unstable relationships and fragile work. In Niagara, it is not unusual to see multi-generational households held together by an elderly matriarch's pension. Calgary's lower northeast or deep south communities reveal similar burdens behind newer suburban facades.

Absent stable partners, many of these women juggle social assistance, part-time jobs with no benefits, and sometimes informal economies — cleaning cash under the table, tending bar, or in the grimmer stories, sex work tied to supporting a drug-involved partner or their own habit. In the best cases, extended families fill the breach. In the worst, children are effectively raised by the state through intervention systems that cycle kids between foster placements and temporary kin arrangements.

Cheap drugs entrench the cycle

Availability of low-cost, potent drugs makes everything worse. In Belleville or Niagara, a point of crystal meth

can be cheaper than a night at the bar. In Ottawa, fentanyl-laced pills undercut old heroin markets with a brutal efficiency. In Calgary, opioid pills and street cocaine flow along the same economic pathways that once trucked oilfield parts.

When small towns lose factories or big cities price families out of housing, cheap highs offer an immediate, if catastrophic, alternative to waiting for a job market that may never fully recover. They deepen dependence not just on the substance, but on transient relationships often structured around scoring and using. And once children enter the picture, a fragile domestic situation becomes a multi-generational trauma pipeline.

What would it take to reverse course?

The antidote is not simply "more treatment beds" or "tougher policing," though both have their places. It starts with rebuilding meaningful economic ecosystems that allow young people — especially young men at risk of slipping into local criminal hierarchies — to envision a life that doesn't orbit around the next fix or the next hustle.

It means reviving pathways into well-paid, skills-based employment. Industrial strategy should not be a relic of the mid-20th century. In Niagara, it could mean advanced agri-tech or precision manufacturing linked to the U.S. border. In Belleville and PEC, scaling beyond seasonal tourism into year-round food processing or green tech. Ottawa, ironically Canada's bureaucracy hub, needs to strengthen private sector tech and trades beyond the public service umbrella. In Calgary, diversification beyond oil remains a cliché on political lips but must materialize tangibly in logistics, renewables, and digital infrastructure.

Housing policy matters equally. Cheap drugs flourish in places where

people lose stable housing and move into extended couch-surfing or precarious rentals that become informal crash pads for dealers and users. Purpose-built affordable housing, coupled with social workers who operate as community navigators, could short-circuit some of the spirals before they begin.

Toward a new social contract

Finally, cultural expectations need to shift. In too many Canadian communities, struggling mothers are left quietly to bear the social cost of male disappearance — whether due to incarceration, addiction, or simple abdication. Programs that support family formation and keep young fathers meaningfully involved could offset much of the cycle that sees the state step in as parent.

Because here is the uncomfortable truth: in the vacuum left by departed industries and unfulfilled economic promises, cheap drugs become the de facto community glue. They structure days, medicate hopelessness, provide an income of sorts, and in doing so, devastate the very family and social systems needed to recover.

To reverse this will take more than sympathy or punitive crackdowns. It will require seeing the drug problem not just as a matter of personal vice but as the inevitable symptom of economic neglect. When opportunity withdraws, something fills its place. And in far too many corners of Canada, that something is a handful of white powder or shards in a pipe — cheaper than hope, and far more destructive.

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Across the Water: The Deep and Complicated Ties Between Belleville, Prince Edward County and the United States

Stand at the shoreline of Prince Edward County or on the banks of the Moira River in Belleville, and it is hard to ignore the invisible line that slices through Lake Ontario and the St. Lawrence — the border that marks where Canada ends and the United States begins. But for centuries, these waters and the land beyond them have been far less about barriers than about connection. The history of Belleville and the County is steeped in the ebb and flow of people, ideas, trade, and conflict with our American neighbours. And in many ways, that relationship remains at the heart of who we are.

Loyalist roots and a revolution's refugees

The defining starting point is often traced to the late 1700s, when the American Revolution upended loyalties and forced thousands to choose sides. Belleville (then known as Meyer's Creek) and Prince Edward County became havens for United Empire Loyalists fleeing the turmoil to the south. Families who had once owned land and businesses in New York, Vermont, or Pennsylvania packed up what they could carry and arrived to carve new lives from the Ontario wilderness.

Their loyalty to the Crown was more than political. It seeded institutions — Anglican churches, local militias, and eventually a governance structure that prized British law and custom. But ironically, these transplanted Americans also brought a robust entrepreneurial spirit, stubborn independence, and farming practices that shaped the region's character. In many families' records you'll find property grants issued by the Crown alongside stories of cousins who remained in the new United States, sketching an early portrait of cross-border kinship.

War of 1812: friends turn adversaries

This close, familial relationship made the War of 1812 a bitter test. Prince Edward County and Hastings County volunteers drilled in anticipation of American raids, and there were real fears the relatively undefended settlements along the Bay of Quinte would become easy pickings. In the end, the region was spared the kind of devastation that befell Niagara, but local men did fight in actions at Kingston and beyond.

The war deepened a psychological border that would linger for decades. American expansionism was viewed with suspicion; loyalty to Britain became a badge of local identity. Yet even this period of tension did not truly sever ties. By the 1830s, trade and travel across the lake had quietly resumed. Schooners from Oswego and Rochester carried goods to Belleville's busy wharves, and farmers on both sides found eager buyers across the water.

A haven for freedom seekers

By mid-century, the relationship took on a profoundly moral dimension. As slavery's cruelties escalated in the United States, Belleville and the County became stops — formal and informal — along the Underground Railroad. Local families harboured freedom seekers, and communities of Black settlers took root in the broader Quinte region. Churches and small farms offered sanctuary where U.S. laws offered only bondage.

This legacy is still visible if you know where to look: historic cemeteries, oral histories, church records. It is a reminder that while Canada and the U.S. shared bloodlines and commerce, they could stand worlds apart on human freedom.

Economic kinship through booms and busts

The 19th century also saw economic ties deepen in ways that would never fully loosen. Belleville's textile mills, foundries, and eventually its bustling railway hub drew on American technology and sometimes American capital. Apples and barley from the County crossed the lake; manufactured goods and luxuries came back. Through Prohibition in the U.S., this trade turned illicit, with rumrunners using the isolated coves of Prince Edward County to ship Canadian whisky south — a small rebellion that brought prosperity even as it thumbed the nose at American laws.

This cross-border trade left an imprint on local attitudes: practical, slightly opportunistic, but always aware that fortunes here were tied to the economic weather south of the border. When the U.S. sneezed, local sawmills and canning plants caught colds.

20th-century modernity and mutual influence

By the 20th century, Belleville and the County's ties to the U.S. were less about survival and more about modernity and lifestyle. American tourists helped shape the County's early reputation as a summer haven, drawn by beaches and fishing. Belleville, meanwhile, adopted American innovations in retail and entertainment — from the first movie houses to auto dealerships stocked with Fords and Chevys.

Families often straddled the border in new ways: children went to college in upstate New York, businesses established small distribution partnerships, and the advent of cheap car travel made shopping trips across the bridge in Ogdensburg or beyond almost routine.

Today: cultural closeness amid economic divergence

Now in the 21st century, Belleville and Prince Edward County's relationship with the United States is both more diffuse and more intimate. Many County wineries market directly to American tourists; Belleville's sports bars fill for NFL games. Streaming and social media ensure that local teens consume as much American pop culture as they do Canadian.

But there's also a quiet wariness. The last few years have exposed vulnerabilities in supply chains that crisscross the border. Political instability south of the lakes makes many here ponder just how tied Canada should remain to its neighbour's fate. The housing boom — partly fuelled by Toronto wealth but also by American investors looking for safe havens — has pushed home prices beyond the reach of many locals, reshaping demographics in ways not everyone welcomes.

What the future might hold

So what does the future look like for this cross-border relationship? It is likely to remain as complicated as ever. Economically, Belleville and the County depend on American tourism and cross-border flows of capital. Culturally, our ties are almost seamless. But politically and socially, there is a renewed appetite for reinforcing what makes this region uniquely Canadian — from its healthcare to its evolving stance on environmental stewardship.

The real opportunity may lie in leveraging this proximity differently: positioning Belleville as a hub for advanced manufacturing that can export into U.S. markets under stable trade agreements, or cementing the County's place as a premier destination for experiential tourism that draws Americans without letting global investors distort local life.

A relationship that is both mirror and foil



Ultimately, Belleville and Prince Edward County's historic relationship with the United States serves as both mirror and foil. It reflects shared histories, kinships, and aspirations — but also underscores the distinct path Canada chose in building social safety nets, embracing multicultural identity, and maintaining public goods like healthcare that Americans still wrestle over.

The story of this region and its ties to the U.S. is neither one of dependency nor rivalry, but of entanglement. In these rolling farmlands and small city streets lies a centuries-old testimony: that borders may be drawn on maps, but real life, trade, and family often flow more like water — finding their way across, reshaping the shores on both sides.

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Serenades by the Lake: How a Portly Guitar Hero Turned a Boring Summer into a Love Song

Emily didn't expect much from her two-week stay at Lake Rosseau. Her best friend had offered her the family cottage for some "soul rejuvenation" after Emily's last relationship had fizzled into a polite exchange of texts and radio silence. The plan was simple: solo mornings on the dock with herbal tea, afternoons lost in paperbacks, and long aimless walks trying to figure out if she wanted to keep her Toronto job or finally risk something different.

It sounded tranquil, restorative—maybe a little too tranquil.

By day three, Emily was already talking to the spiders that colonized the boathouse. By day four, she was naming them. "Good morning, Rupert. Don't eat any big flies without me." The lake was stunning, framed by emerald pines and the hazy scent of cedar and barbecue from distant cottages. But Emily was beginning to wonder if she could overdose on peace and quiet. She'd only seen one kayak glide by in 48 hours, and her phone reception was as moody as her playlists.

Then he arrived.

A troubadour in cargo shorts

On the afternoon of day five, while Emily was half asleep on the dock, a gentle strumming drifted over the water. At first she thought it was someone's Bluetooth speaker from across the bay. But the sound grew richer, closer. She lifted her sunglasses—and nearly choked on her iced tea.

Paddling toward her dock was a stocky man in a faded straw hat, a floral button-down that strained heroically over his rounded middle, and the biggest grin she'd ever seen. Propped across his lap was an old acoustic guitar. He paddled with one hand, strummed with the other, and somehow didn't tip over.

"Permission to land?" he called, voice carrying easily across the water.

Emily burst out laughing. "As long as you promise not to charge docking fees."

Songs and snorts of laughter

His name was Sam. He was staying with cousins two cottages over. Within minutes of tying off his canoe, he'd tuned his guitar and launched into an adorably earnest rendition of "Stand by Me." Emily clapped, not quite sure how to behave. It felt like she was the star of her own quirky indie film.

When he switched to an upbeat folk song that rhymed "mosquito" with "burrito," she snorted so hard iced tea shot out her nose. Sam beamed like he'd just received a standing ovation.

"You're either my best audience or my most entertaining heckler," he teased.

They spent the rest of the afternoon trading embarrassing Spotify favorites and sunburn horror stories. Emily learned that Sam was a civil engineer who moonlighted in a local pub band. His cousins had lured him up for the summer under the promise of unlimited fishing and zero wedding planning duties—he was freshly out of a failed engagement.

"I thought I was coming here to mope in sweatpants," he admitted. "Didn't figure I'd meet a girl in a floppy hat with better dance moves than me."

Emily protested she had no rhythm, but he only grinned wider.

The courtship of chaos

The next few days turned into an unexpected comedy of romantic mishaps.

On Saturday, Sam invited Emily to a sunset picnic on a rocky outcrop across the lake. They managed to tip the canoe trying to clink cans of

ginger beer. They swam the last ten metres, howling with laughter, Emily's sun hat floating away like a little lost boat.

On Sunday, Sam serenaded her again—this time under a porch lantern that attracted every moth in Muskoka. One particularly determined giant moth dive-bombed his nose mid-chorus. He squealed, dropped the guitar, and smacked himself so hard Emily thought he'd broken something. She laughed until tears ran down her cheeks, then kissed him right on the freckle at the tip of his nose.

Monday brought rain, so they huddled in the cottage's tiny kitchen cooking chili that turned out so spicy Sam actually hiccuped for a full ten minutes. Emily was convinced she'd poisoned her new crush. But Sam pulled her into a gentle, hiccupy sway, and whispered, "Best meal I've ever almost died eating."

The music that mended

Somewhere between these goofy chapters, Emily's dull summer evolved into a warm, rambling ballad.

She realized how good it felt to be with someone who didn't shy away from life's slapstick moments. Sam was a terrible dancer, a brave cook, and a brilliant listener. In between joking about the worst pop songs of the 90s, he asked about her stalled marketing career, her dreams of freelancing, and the family scars she rarely showed. He strummed soft little progressions that seemed to untangle her worries.

One star-filled night, with the lake perfectly still, he played a song he'd written years ago. It was about being scared to love again, about hoping to find someone whose laughter made the risk worth it.

Emily sat beside him on the dock, her head on his shoulder, tears drying unnoticed. When he finished, she turned his face toward hers and kissed him slow and certain.

Not quite a fairytale

Their cottage romance didn't wrap up with a Hollywood flourish. Emily still had to go back to Toronto. Sam had projects waiting in Ottawa. They promised to figure things out over September, swap weekends, and see where the music took them.

But Emily knew, in that warm echoing space between guitar strings and heartbeats, that Sam had already rescued her. Not in some dramatic hero-storms-the-castle way. He rescued her from her own dreary script, the one that said being single at thirty meant settling for small joys.

He showed up—portly, sunburned, slightly out of tune—and turned her lonely lake retreat into the beginning of the best song she'd ever heard.

The last laugh

When they packed up on her final morning, Sam slipped a little notebook into her tote. Inside were scribbled lyrics: half-finished choruses about canoes, sun hats, chili-induced near-death experiences.

"Next summer, we'll finish them," he promised. "You sing; I'll hiccup."

Emily threw her arms around him, laughing, already composing her reply.

Because sometimes love doesn't come galloping in with six-pack abs and serious declarations. Sometimes it arrives by canoe, belly-first, guitar slung over one shoulder, singing silly songs that somehow become the soundtrack to the life you've been hoping to live.

BAROMETERS.CA SPORTS



Sports Round-Up

Barometers.ca *is a Lifestyle Magazine and a big part of Lifestyle communities is local sport. Since we upload the Sunday Weekly issue on early Saturday morning you will see all the various recaps of the games including Friday's action in the next pages.*

BELLEVILLE

Explosive Distances and Community Spirit: Endless Summer Hits Belleville

If it wasn't clear before, it's undeniable now: Belleville has firmly planted itself on the map as a world-class venue for long-drive golf. Over the weekend of June 13–14, Trillium Wood Golf Club came alive with the fifth annual Endless Summer Long-Drive Championship. Drawing nearly 1,500 spectators from across Canada and the U.S., the event transformed the course into a high-energy arena of raw power, precision, and celebration.

From the inaugural Military Hitter's Showdown—which added flair and patriotism with a Hercules flypast and a Skyhawks parachute display—to the thrilling nighttime finals under the lights, the weekend combined sport, spectacle, and community. But the real reason fans showed up? The incredible feats of ball-striking witnessed on every tee.

In the women's division, Canada's own Kelly Rudney soared to victory with a jaw-dropping 347-yard drive—her first title in this prestigious global series. Rudney's massive blast wasn't just long; it was dominant—clearly outpacing her nearest competitor by nearly 20 yards. For local golf fans who see the effort and dedication behind every swing, Rudney's win was a source of hometown pride and inspiration: proof that power and technique, honed on our shared fairways, can shine on the world stage.

The men's final was equally breathtaking. Jack Smith, a long-



drive prodigy from Louisiana, unleashed a 421-yard rocket to claim the men's crown—leaving the 2024 champion trailing in his wake. To put that into perspective: that drive would've rolled through two regulation fairways. Smith's performance was a masterclass in raw strength meeting flawless mechanics, and it drew cheers from a captivated crowd that gasped with every explosive thwack and soaring carry.

Between the thrilling on-course competition, Trillium Wood became a hub of entertainment. A live DJ kept spirits high. Fans followed their favourite hitters as they moved from station to station, and families settled into bleachers with lawn chairs, drinks, and smiles, ready to

soak in the excitement. The energy was electric—and inspiring.

Beyond the vying for titles, Endless Summer's charitable impact was a highlight. Partnering with the United Way of Hastings and Prince Edward, alongside the Trenton Military Family Resource Centre, the event directed a portion of ticket proceeds toward local causes. It was a weekend not just about distance, but about doing good—blending athletic achievement with community care.

For Belleville, this kind of event reinforces the city's position as a summer sports destination. It's a reminder that the region can host Saturday night thrillers under floodlights just as naturally as hockey games and festivals. Over time, it builds identity: Belleville isn't just watching events happen—it's making history happen.

The tournament's growth reflects the increasing popularity of long-drive golf in Canada. In its early years, the competition drew several hundred fans; now its standing rivals that of major sporting days. For local businesses—from food vendors to tourism operators—the weekend brought an influx of visitors, spending, and visibility. For residents, it offered a taste of power sport that many have never witnessed so close to home.

For the athletes, Trillium Wood delivered more than a stage—it was a forge. With familiar fairways and local support, they thrived. Rudney's steady nerves and raw horsepower impressed her supporters; Smith's sheer distance made believers of skeptics. Both champions wore their titles with pride, but it was their mutual respect—across gender and geography—that truly captured hearts.

The competition didn't just happen under the glow of floodlights; it took form years ago in practice swings, in muscle memory built on Belleville greens, and in borrowed training gear stuffed into trunks. Fans could sense

it in the players' focus, in a smoothing follow-through, in a confident stroll after a drive that roared 350+ yards. It was the product of effort, environment, and belief—a fitting narrative for a region proud of its sporting roots.

What's next? Endless Summer is already eyeing an even bigger 2026 edition—its fifth anniversary—aiming to build on record attendance and community momentum. With hosting spots like Trillium Wood, Belleville could soon become the unofficial home of long-drive excellence in Canada. Locals are talking about enhanced course lighting, more interactive zones, and new divisions to expand appeal. It's evolving fast.

For now, the weekend's final image is hard to shake: Rudney's powerful swing during the women's final, Smith's rocket final drive piercing night air, crowds erupting in applause, and four golf balls landing beyond expectation. Add charity checks presented with gratitude, local businesses buzzing, and media lines spread across Canadian and U.S. outlets—the narrative blends spectacle and substance, performance and purpose.

This isn't just an event summary—it's a portrait of a community hitting its stride. More specifically, of a region discovering that it has the stage, the crowd, and the heart to host world-class sport. And whether your interest lies in golf, event planning, or civic pride—you'd be hard-pressed to find a better example than last weekend's long-drive showdown at Trillium Wood.

In the weeks to come, organizers will refine plans; athletes will book hotels; local sponsors will rally. But for those who witnessed it, the message is simple: Belleville can handle the big hits—on the course and off. And in that blend lies the promise of something even greater next summer.

NIAGARA

BASEBALL

Maple Leafs Silence Jackfish with Timely Hits and Strong Pitching

The Toronto Maple Leafs celebrated Canada Day with a gritty 4–2 victory over the league-leading Welland Jackfish in front of over 3,200 fans at Welland Stadium. The Leafs broke a scoreless deadlock in the fifth inning and capitalized on defensive miscues by Welland, pushing across three more runs in the sixth and seventh frames. Jhon Javier stayed hot at the plate, collecting two hits including an RBI single, while Dan Marra drove in another run with a sacrifice fly. Toronto starter Josh Berenbaum delivered a quality outing, scattering five hits over six shutout innings with five strikeouts to earn the win, supported by Nathan Currah and Luis Florentino who held off Welland's late push.

Welland mounted a rally in the bottom of the ninth when Pier-Olivier Boucher's two-out single plated a pair, but Toronto's earlier insurance proved decisive. Despite outhitting Toronto 9–7, the Jackfish were undone by four errors and stranded nine baserunners. James Bradwell pitched well in a no-decision, striking out six over five innings and allowing only one unearned run. The loss drops Welland to 14-6 while the Leafs even their record at 11-11, tightening the standings as both clubs look ahead to pivotal matchups later this week.

Jackfish Reel In Red Sox with Strong Middle Innings

The Welland Jackfish powered past the Brantford Red Sox 9-3 on Thursday night at Welland Stadium, thanks to explosive third and fourth innings that put the game out of reach early. Welland struck for four runs in the third, highlighted by timely hits from Matteo Porcellato and Brett Hupe, and then added

three more in the fourth to open up a commanding lead. Shortstop Justin Weisner was a catalyst at the top of the order, reaching base four times, stealing two bases, and driving in a run, while Hupe doubled twice and drove in another to keep the pressure on Brantford's pitchers.

Despite the loss, the Red Sox had their moments, clawing back with two runs in the fourth on a two-run single by Carlos Ortega. However, the Welland bullpen shut the door from there, striking out seven over the final three innings to preserve José Domínguez's win. Domínguez went six solid innings, scattering seven hits and three earned runs with six strikeouts. The victory pushes Welland to 15-6 on the season, while Brantford drops to 6-17, still searching for consistency on the mound and more timely offense.

/ Saturday

Welland travels to Brantford today at 2pm.

Basketball

Honey Badgers Rout River Lions with Stifling Defense and Sharp Shooting

The Brampton Honey Badgers put on a commanding performance Tuesday night, rolling to a 91-66 win over the Niagara River Lions. Brampton came out firing from beyond the arc and never let up, building a double-digit lead in the first quarter that ballooned as the game wore on. Marcus Carr ran the offense with poise, knocking down key shots and dishing out crisp assists, while David Muenkat and Amari Kelly delivered timely three-pointers and putbacks to keep the pressure on Niagara's defense. Brampton's tenacious on-ball defense forced numerous turnovers, stifling any momentum Niagara tried to muster.

Niagara, meanwhile, struggled to find an offensive rhythm, with standout efforts from Ahmed Hill and Kimbal Mackenzie providing only

brief sparks. The River Lions were outpaced in transition and hampered by costly turnovers, unable to close the gap as Brampton's balanced attack proved too much to handle. With the win, the Honey Badgers reinforced their reputation as one of the CEBL's most disciplined and explosive squads, while Niagara heads back to regroup after a humbling night on the road.

River Lions Clamp Down Late to Top Sea Bears 93-82

The Niagara River Lions used a strong fourth-quarter surge to secure a 93-82 win over the Winnipeg Sea Bears in a tightly contested matchup. After trading baskets early, Niagara found separation through a pair of critical three-pointers from Khalil Ahmad and Ron Curry, while Guillaume Boucard anchored the defense with timely rebounds and blocks. Winnipeg, led by Jalen Harris and Emmanuel Akot, clawed back repeatedly, cutting the deficit to as little as five in the fourth, but struggled to find consistent scoring in crunch time. Niagara's poise at the free-throw line and their ability to generate turnovers proved decisive.

The River Lions leaned on balanced scoring throughout, with important contributions from Edward Ekiyor inside and Kimbal Mackenzie's perimeter shooting helping to maintain the lead. Meanwhile, Winnipeg's Harris poured in clutch threes to keep the Sea Bears within striking distance but was ultimately contained down the stretch. With this win, Niagara solidifies its playoff aspirations, showcasing a blend of veteran leadership and late-game composure that could make them a tough out as the season progresses.

OTTAWA

Football

Toronto Outlasts Ottawa in CFL Showdown Defined by Turnovers and Defense

In a gritty contest marked by sacks, turnovers, and explosive special teams plays, the Toronto Argonauts ultimately outlasted the Ottawa Redblacks. The game's pivotal moment came midway through the fourth quarter when Ottawa wide receiver Kalil Pimpleton fumbled near the Toronto goal line after a promising drive, and Argos defensive back D'Shawn Slywka scooped it up, racing an astonishing 105 yards for a defensive touchdown. That crushing blow shifted momentum firmly in Toronto's favor. Earlier, the Redblacks had clawed their way back with strong drives led by quarterback Dustin Crum, only to see promising possessions stall due to a combination of sacks—Toronto's front seven repeatedly breaking through—and a missed field goal that turned into yet another Toronto major after a long return.

The Argonauts' offense, led by Nick Arbuckle, did just enough, mixing short completions with key deep strikes to Dejon Brissett and Damonte Coxie to keep Ottawa's defense honest. Lirim Hajrullahu's steady kicking added critical points, including multiple field goals from over 40 yards. Meanwhile, Ottawa's own kicker Lewis Ward had mixed results, converting from long range but also seeing one crucial attempt blocked. In the end, Toronto's ability to capitalize on Ottawa's miscues and their defensive resilience at key moments proved to be the difference, allowing them to escape with a hard-fought victory in front of their home crowd.

Ottawa Travels to Edmonton for a game today at 7 pm.

Basketball

Ottawa BlackJacks overpower Winnipeg Sea Bears with strong second half surge

The Ottawa BlackJacks seized control in the second half to secure a commanding 104-80 victory over the Winnipeg Sea Bears. Ottawa's

offense came alive in the third and fourth quarters, with Javonte Smart orchestrating the attack and Deng Adel and Isaih Moore consistently capitalizing on their opportunities. Ottawa used a series of timely three-pointers from Smart, Shakur Daniel, and Tyrrel Tate to keep Winnipeg chasing. After a competitive first half where Winnipeg pulled within six, Ottawa's relentless pace and depth ultimately wore the Sea Bears down.

Winnipeg showed flashes of resilience behind Jalen Harris, Emmanuel Akot, and Simi Shittu, who combined for multiple runs that cut the deficit to single digits in the third. However, turnovers and missed opportunities at the free-throw line prevented the Sea Bears from closing the gap. Ottawa's defense clamped down in the fourth quarter, forcing rushed shots and converting defensive stops into transition points. The win cements the BlackJacks' momentum as they continue to position themselves as serious contenders heading into the heart of the season.

Rattlers Edge BlackJacks in Thrilling Finish

The Saskatchewan Rattlers pulled off a dramatic 93-90 comeback win over the Ottawa BlackJacks in a tense Canadian Elite Basketball League (CEBL) showdown. Ottawa built multiple double-digit leads behind strong play from Javonte Smart, Zane Waterman and Keevan Veinot, who combined for key buckets and a late fourth-quarter cushion. Smart was especially clutch with multiple three-pointers to keep Ottawa ahead by as many as 12 midway through the final frame. However, Saskatchewan's resilience shone through thanks to the stellar shooting of Jordan Bowden and Grant Anticevich, who each hit crucial triples in the closing minutes.

In the final minute, Bowden nailed a three to tie it at 90-90, and then Anticevich buried a dagger from beyond the arc to give Saskatchewan

a three-point edge. Ottawa had one last chance but missed a tying attempt, sealing the victory for the Rattlers. Nate Pierre-Louis orchestrated several critical assists down the stretch, helping Saskatchewan erase what was once a daunting fourth-quarter deficit. The win improves the Rattlers' standing in the playoff race while handing Ottawa a tough loss despite a well-balanced offensive outing.

Soccer (no games)

CALGARY

SOCCER (no games)

Football

Stampede on the Scoreboard: Stampeders Charge Past Blue Bombers

The Calgary Stampeders overwhelmed the Winnipeg Blue Bombers 37-16 on home turf in a game that was decided early by a relentless defensive and special teams performance. Calgary jumped out to a commanding lead by halftime, capitalizing on key turnovers and big returns. Defensive back Darnell Moncrief set the tone with a 70-yard pick-six in the fourth quarter to crush Winnipeg's late comeback hopes, while fellow defensive back Darius Webb also returned an interception 30 yards for a touchdown in the first quarter. Running back Dedrick Mills anchored Calgary's ground game, consistently moving the chains with tough inside runs, and finished with multiple first downs that kept the Bomber defense on the field.

For Winnipeg, quarterback Zach Collaros and running back Brady Oliveira put together some promising drives, but they often stalled in Calgary territory, settling for three field goals from Sergio Castillo. Collaros did connect with Jerreth Sterns for a late touchdown, but it was too little too late as Calgary's pass rush and opportunistic secondary clamped down. With the

win, the Stampeders improved their position in the West Division, while the Blue Bombers will need to regroup quickly to keep pace in a tightening playoff race.

Basketball

Calgary Surge Outlast Honey Badgers in Physical Contest

The Calgary Surge powered their way to a 94-85 win over the Brampton Honey Badgers in a rugged, high-tempo matchup. Calgary's consistent early scoring laid the foundation, jumping out to a 27-11 first-quarter lead thanks to Jamorko Pickett and Evan Gilyard Jr., who were instrumental with quick transition points and perimeter shooting. Greg Brown III and Sean Miller-Moore added physical inside play, combining for key dunks and defensive stops. Calgary's aggressive defense forced multiple turnovers, building a lead that swelled to 22 points by the third quarter.

Brampton rallied hard in the fourth, led by Marcus Carr and Prince Oduro, who attacked the paint and cut the deficit to as little as seven points. However, critical baskets from Pickett and late-game free throws by Gilyard Jr. kept the Surge comfortably ahead. Despite the Honey Badgers' push and a flurry of steals by Quinndary Weatherspoon, Calgary's balanced offense and timely rebounds sealed the win. The victory helps the Surge solidify their playoff positioning, while Brampton will look to regroup after another close but frustrating finish.

Today Edmonton and Calgary square off in Edmonton at 6 pm.

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Pomeroy's Barometers

BELLEVILLE & THE COUNTY
NIAGARA
OTTAWA
July 6, 2025 CALGARY & ALBERTA



World Week in Review

Stories of interest from around the world from this past week.

1. U.S.–EU Tariff Deadline Looms July 9

President Trump has confirmed that the 90-day suspension of sweeping new tariffs—ranging from 10% up to 70%—will end on July 9. This has put intense pressure on America's key trading partners, including the EU, Japan, and South Korea, to finalize new trade terms. The U.S. has already begun issuing formal notices of impending tariffs, escalating urgency. The European Union is reportedly prepared to accept a minimum 10% tariff level to protect broader trade flows, but continues to resist much steeper duties on critical sectors like automotive, meat, steel, and aluminum.

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2. Global Markets Dip Amid Trade Anxiety

World financial markets reacted with pronounced caution to the looming tariff deadline. Equity futures slid, with the S&P 500 down around 0.6%, European shares off by nearly 1%, and Asian markets broadly retreating. Commodities such as oil and copper also lost ground, while the U.S. dollar weakened. Investors are increasingly factoring in the potential for slower global growth and disrupted supply chains if large-scale tariffs are imposed.

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3. EU Pushes for Immediate Tariff Exemptions

As negotiations accelerate, Brussels is pressing for a "framework" agreement with Washington that would delay the tariff implementation date and immediately lift levies on major European exports like spirits, aircraft parts, pharmaceuticals, and semiconductors. The EU also wants existing 25% tariffs on cars and 50% on steel and aluminum rolled back. With the deadline only days away, these talks are seen as critical to shielding Europe's economy from heavy new costs.

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4. Europe Battles Record-Breaking Heatwave

Countries across Europe are sweltering under unprecedented heat, with Spain, Portugal, the UK, Germany, and Italy all experiencing temperatures soaring above 46 °C. This brutal heatwave has caused a spike in heat-related illnesses and deaths, forced school closures, strained power grids, and sparked numerous wildfires. Climate scientists caution that such extreme weather events are quickly becoming Europe's new normal as global warming accelerates.

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5. Mediterranean Wildfires Trigger Mass Evacuations

Simultaneously, intense wildfires have erupted throughout the Mediterranean region, including Greece, Turkey, Portugal, France, Spain, and parts of Germany. Thousands have been forced to flee their homes, with dozens of casualties reported and approximately 52,000 people evacuated from threatened zones in Turkey alone. Fire crews continue to battle the blazes amid relentless heat and dry conditions.

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6. U.S.–Ukraine Air Defence Pact

On July 4, President Trump and Ukrainian President Zelenskyy held a pivotal call to solidify a new defense arrangement. The two leaders agreed on expanding U.S. support for Ukraine's air defense capabilities, including plans to co-manufacture missile systems and anti-drone technology. This move is aimed at fortifying Ukraine against continuing aerial assaults in its conflict with Russia, underlining a strategic partnership that could reshape Eastern Europe's security dynamics.

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7. India's Modi Undertakes Major Diplomatic Tour

Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched his largest diplomatic tour

in a decade, spanning July 2–9, with stops in Ghana, Trinidad & Tobago, Argentina, Brazil (for the BRICS summit), and Namibia. This ambitious trip aims to boost India's global standing by deepening trade ties, securing energy and technology partnerships, and reinforcing multilateral cooperation across diverse regions.

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8. BYD Surpasses Tesla in Global EV Sales

China's BYD has cemented its dominance over Tesla in the global electric vehicle market, delivering roughly 607,000 battery electric vehicles in the second quarter—dramatically outpacing Tesla's estimated 384,000. While BYD's total EV output (including hybrids) grew nearly 15% over the previous quarter, Tesla reported a notable year-over-year decline in deliveries. This signals a striking power shift in the race for EV market leadership.

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9. China Lifts Seafood Ban on Japan

Beijing has officially lifted its ban on Japanese seafood imports, a prohibition originally imposed after Japan began releasing treated wastewater from the Fukushima nuclear plant in 2023. The end of the ban restores Japan's access to a valuable export market and marks a significant thaw in bilateral trade relations after years of strain.

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10. Poland Elects Conservative President

Poland's political landscape is set for change after historian Karol Nawrocki won the presidency in a close runoff against Rafał Trzaskowski. Nawrocki's victory signals a shift toward more conservative domestic policies and potentially a recalibration of Poland's approach within the European Union, raising expectations of new debates over judicial reforms, migration, and EU funding.

Pomeroy's Barometers

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Canada in Review

Stories in Canada from this past week.

Canada rescinds digital services tax to restart U.S. trade talks

In a significant economic pivot, Canada repealed its 3% digital services tax that had primarily targeted major American tech giants such as Google, Meta, and Amazon. This came after President Trump threatened to walk away from trade negotiations unless the tax was dropped. Ottawa's move immediately defused a transatlantic trade spat and unlocked stalled discussions with Washington aimed at forging a new bilateral trade deal by July 21. Canadian officials called the decision painful but necessary to protect broader export markets, especially automotive and agriculture, from potential U.S. retaliation.

U.S.–Canada trade negotiations resume immediately

Following Canada's rollback of its controversial tech tax, the White House announced that intensive trade talks between the two nations would resume without delay. Officials from both sides convened virtually and in Washington starting June 30 to hammer out unresolved issues, with hopes of securing a deal that updates provisions on automotive rules, steel tariffs, agricultural quotas, and digital commerce. The renewed dialogue eased fears of a summer tariff battle that could have deeply impacted Canadian manufacturers and farmers.

Canada fast-tracks natural resource and infrastructure approvals

Seeking to stimulate the economy amid global trade pressures and to capitalize on critical mineral demand, Canada's Senate passed legislation to streamline approvals for large-scale mining, energy, and infrastructure projects. The new measures aim to cut permitting times by up to half while still upholding environmental reviews. Prime Minister Carney framed it as essential to keeping Canada competitive and securing supply chains for strategic resources like lithium, nickel, and rare earths, vital for electric vehicle and defense manufacturing.

Canadian services sector hits contraction in June

New data showed Canada's services sector remained under heavy strain, with the S&P Global Services PMI dropping to 44.3 in June—well below the 50 mark that separates growth from contraction. It was the seventh straight month of shrinking activity. Hospitality, real estate services, and logistics were especially weak, with executives citing uncertainty around trade policy, rising borrowing costs, and tight consumer spending. Economists warned this persistent slump in services could drag on GDP growth through the second half of the year.

Canadian dollar weakens on economic jitters The Canadian dollar ended the week slightly weaker at around 1.3605 to the U.S. dollar, reflecting investor caution after the poor services PMI print compounded worries over domestic economic momentum. Earlier in the week the loonie had advanced on stronger oil prices and optimism over trade talks. Currency analysts noted that if trade disputes with the U.S. were reignited, or if the domestic services downturn deepened further, it could spark a sharper selloff in the coming weeks.

Canada awaits private-sector proposal for Pacific pipeline Canada's natural resources minister called on energy companies to formally propose plans for a new pipeline to carry crude oil from Alberta to the Pacific coast, potentially ending at Prince Rupert. While Ottawa signaled it would support such a project, it stopped short of championing it outright, indicating the initiative must come from industry. The pipeline could unlock Asian export markets and relieve capacity constraints, but would also reignite contentious debates over Indigenous land rights, environmental safeguards, and climate targets. **Canada builds new icebreakers to assert Arctic role** In a push to reinforce sovereignty and prepare for increased shipping through the melting Arctic, Canada signed contracts with Seaspan and Davie Shipyards to build a fleet of modern polar-class icebreakers. These ships are slated to patrol and support navigation through the Northwest

Passage, facilitate scientific missions, and provide rapid response for search-and-rescue. The government argued that with Russia expanding its Arctic military footprint and new global shipping lanes opening, Canada must have a credible presence to secure its northern interests.

Penny Oleksiak withdraws from World Championships Canada's most decorated Olympian, swimmer Penny Oleksiak, withdrew from the 2025 World Aquatics Championships over a "whereabouts" administrative compliance issue—a rule requiring athletes to keep anti-doping agencies informed of their location for out-of-competition tests. Oleksiak stressed there was no doping allegation involved but admitted to regrettable oversights that left her unable to compete. Her absence is a blow to Canada's medal hopes in the pool just a year ahead of the next Olympic Games.

Canadian wildfires persist across multiple provinces Canada continued to battle an intense wildfire season, with over 2,600 active fires burning across Manitoba, Ontario, Saskatchewan, Quebec, and British Columbia. More than 4.3 million hectares have been scorched so far this year—surpassing the decade average—and the fires have killed at least two people and forced tens of thousands to flee their homes. Smoke blanketed several urban centers, triggering air quality warnings, while firefighting crews faced relentless heat and dry conditions.

Line Spike music festival debuts in Ontario Ontario welcomed a brand-new cultural event as the inaugural "Line Spike Frontenac" festival kicked off near Harrowsmith over June 28–29. Featuring an all-Canadian lineup that included rising indie bands and established folk-rock acts, the festival managed to proceed despite organizers scrambling to secure last-minute liquor licensing. Attendees praised the local food trucks, craft brews, and relaxed atmosphere, raising hopes that the event will become a summer staple for Eastern Ontario's live music scene.


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